

Ode to Horsetail

Healing *with* Horsetail



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Horsetail Guidance

Indigenous healers showed me that animals are guides to connect us with our plant allies, and Deer has shown me Horsetail, reminding me of the gift of song this plant honored me with a few years ago, while gathering medicine for a Cowichan Elder. The song was a deep vibration that created a sense of slow-motion time, vocals without words in a complex joyous pattern that lifted my spirit.

This was the inspiration for my research inquiry. In the first Spring, I began with an exploratory healing journey with the horsetail plant...

so that I could pull together the many ways I have learned to listen, observe and be present with plants. I documented my process, starting with a week-long cleanse to prepare my body. In many cultures, medicine people practice strict diets to receive the medicine of one plant, allowing them to observe the responses of their body when it interacts with the plant. Prayers and rituals further clear the body of negative energy so it can receive knowledge in a sacred way.

Sitting with Horsetail, I listened for guidance on how to proceed, so my journey would be emergent and inquiry-based, as I allowed myself to be transformed along with Horsetail on this journey. I ingested fresh young stalks and prepared a tea. Depending on the insights I received through my intuition and dreams, I made different remedies. I juiced the stalks and preserved them with honey or vinegar. And I prepared a combo with nettle tops also freshly unfurling at this time. Later, I gathered aerial parts that resembled a “horse tail” to be dried and preserved for medicine-making later in the year.

In the mornings, I worked with the plant spirit medicine of Horsetail, and in the afternoons, I allowed this gathered energy to direct my inquiry to explore the different ways that others have known this plant, setting an intention to understand how humans sustain our symbiotic relationships with plants and support each other to thrive. By reconstructing the knowledge others have gleaned about Horsetail, I synthesized a new understanding of Horsetail’s value and essential role to our planetary survival, while transforming myself in the process.

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Horsetail Medicine

In the Pacific Northwest, Horsetail grows in low lying wet areas, along creeks and stream sides, and in moist ditches. It is commonly found growing alongside Western Skunk Cabbage, Lady Fern, and Red Alder. On Vancouver Island, the new shoots of Giant Horsetail may be ready to harvest as early as mid-March when they start to send up a tall fleshy stalk. The harvest season usually lasts until late April.

Horsetail is best harvested in early spring. During the early stages of growth the Horsetail plants have soluble silica flowing in the stems. The stalks can be harvested anytime before the leaves reach a 45 degree angle off the stalk, after this time the silica in the plant becomes less bio-available. It is best to not use older plants for internal use as they can contain mineral crystals that can be irritating to the kidneys.

New spring shoots are at the perfect stage for juicing, use in teas, infused vinegar, infused honey, and tinctures. Each preparation contains large amounts of the healing silica mineral beneficial for repairing tissues. The tincture contains more of the anti-inflammatory compounds which are helpful for allergies, as a bladder tonic, and alterative.

The fresh plant is generally considered a more potent medicine compared to the dried plant. The dried plant keeps for about three months before losing its colour, but should maintain its mineral content and be useable for that purpose for up to a year. However, anti-inflammatory compounds dissipate quickly after drying.

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Horsetailing around

Verb: to horsetail (2023)

living fossils, opening up deep time,
past-present-future in one
Upsprung: bi-sexual plants,
popping up, up, up in the spring
jumping spores using humidity
transporting *ki* to new zones
expanding rhizomatic networks
colonizing underground realms
photosynthesizing thru spiky leaves
like a plasma ball:
electric signaling thru touch sensing silica
transmitting & receiving signals
more sophisticated than manufactured silicon,
transporting water thru tubular stems and rhizomes
pulling through minerals and nutrients
regulating steady flow of water thru earth bodies
healing from within, horsetail
remembering plantcestors are we

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Being *with* Horsetail

An invitation: being horsetail

- ▽ imagine a time before humans, animals and birds, a time before dinosaurs when Calamite plantcestors moved from water onto the land
- ▽ notice molecules of water within resonating to raindrops, waves, streams, waterfalls, and wells
- ▽ listen without your ears, opening your heart as wide as this world

This proposition is inspired by Yoko Ono's "Touch Poems" as a tribute to the art of Nam June Paik (1960s), who stated that "it has to do with communication on a different dimension."

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How can I heal with horsetail?

My ecological consciousness shifts when I consider how:

Plants are interdependent ecological being, plants are my kin

My ancestral lineage began with horsetail plantcestors 320 mya

Reciprocal exchange is amplified by ingesting, conspiring *with*

The greening power of plants activates my vital energy

Accessing plant time opens a portal to non-linear dimensions

Imaginal art practices allow exploration within relational spaces

Active listening *with* other species shifts my proprioception

Plant songs open my heart to learn in embodied ways